Siddhars. There are different opinions on the constitution of 18 Siddhars. The Siddhars are not only from Tamil Nadu, but have also come from other countries. The entire knowledge is documented in the form of poems in Tamil. Siddha is principally based on the **Pancabūta** philosophy. According to this system three humors namely **Vātam, Pittam** and **Kapam** that are responsible for the health of human beings and any disturbance in the equilibrium of these humors result in ill health. The drug sources of Siddha include plants, animal parts, marine products and minerals. This system specializes in using minerals for preparing drugs with the long shelf-life. This system uses about 800 herbs as source of drugs. Great stress is laid on disease prevention, health promotion, rejuvenation and cure.

Ayurveda system of medicine

Ayurveda supposed to have originated from Brahma. The core knowledge is documented by **Charaka, Sushruta** and **Vagbhata** in compendiums written by them. This system is also based on three humor principles namely, Vatha, Pitha and Kapha which would exist in equilibrium for a healthy living. This system Uses more of herbs and few animal parts as drug sources. Plant sources include a good proportion of Himalayan plants. The **Ayurvedic Pharmacopoeia** of India lists about 500 plants used as source of drugs.

Folk system of medicine

Folk systems survive as an oral tradition among innumerable rural and tribal communities of India. A consolidated study to document the plants used by ethnic communities was launched by the Ministry of Environment and Forests, Government of India in the form of All India Coordinated Research Project on Ethnobiology. As a result about 8000 plant species have been documented which are used for medicinal purposes. The efforts to document in several under-explored and unexplored pockets of India still continue. Major tribal communities in Tamil Nadu who are known for their medicinal knowledge include **Irulas, Malayalis, Kurumbas, Paliyans** and **Kaanis**. Some of the important medicinal plants are discussed below.

10.10 Medicinal Plants

India is a treasure house of medicinal plants. They are linked to local heritage as well as to global-trade. All institutional systems in India primarily use medicinal plants as drug sources. At present, 90% collection of medicinal plants is from the non-cultivated sources. Growing demand for herbal products has led to quantum jump in volume of plant materials traded within and across the countries. Increasing demand exerts a heavy strain on the existing resources. Now efforts are being made to introduce cultivation techniques of medicinal plants to the farmers.

Medicinal plants play a significant role in providing primary health care services to rural and tribal people. They serve as therapeutic agents as well as important raw materials for the manufacture of traditional and modern medicines. Medicinally useful molecules obtained from plants that are marketed as drugs are called Biomedicines. Medicinal plants which are marketed as powders or in other modified forms are known as Botanical medicines. In this chapter you will be learning about a few medicinal plants that are commonly used in Tamil Nadu. All these plants are commonly available in and around dwelling places and can be easily cultivated in home gardens.

Keezhanelli

Botanical name : *Phyllanthus amarus*

Family : Euphorbiaceae (Now in Phyllanthaceae)

Origin and Area of cultivation: The plant is a native of Tropical American region and is naturalised in India and other tropical countries. It is not cultivated and is collected from moist

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